BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 1:

THE SEA

CHENNAI KEEPS ITS BACK TO THE REST OF INDIA AND ITS FACE TO THE OCEAN. EVERYONE WHO GROWS UP NEAR THE PORT KNOWS THIS — THE CITY IS ORIENTED TOWARD WATER THE WAY A SUNFLOWER IS ORIENTED TOWARD LIGHT.

NOT WORSHIP, EXACTLY. JUST ACKNOWLEDGEMENT THAT THE SEA IS WHAT THE CITY RUNS ON.

ZARA SHAIKH LEARNED TO SWIM AT FOUR YEARS OLD IN THE ADYAR RIVER, WHICH WAS NOT A CLEAN RIVER.

BUT HER FATHER SAID THE BACTERIA BUILT CHARACTER.

The bacteria build character.

HAMID SHAIKH SAID A LOT OF THINGS. SOME OF THEM WERE EVEN TRUE.

HAMID SHAIKH WORKED THE DOCKS AT CHENNAI PORT — A STEVEDORE, THEN A FOREMAN, THEN A MAN WHO KNEW WHICH SHIPPING MANIFESTS TO LOOK AT AND WHICH TO LEAVE ALONE.

HE WAS NOT A GOOD MAN IN THE WAY CIVIC SOCIETY DEFINES GOODNESS. HE WAS A GOOD FATHER IN THE WAY FATHERS WHO WORK DANGEROUS JOBS IN SYSTEMS DESIGNED TO GRIND THEM DOWN CAN BE: PRESENT, WATCHFUL, HONEST ABOUT WHAT THE WORLD WAS, CLEAR ABOUT WHAT HE WANTED BETTER FOR HIS CHILDREN.

HIS SON IMRAN, FOUR YEARS OLDER THAN ZARA, TURNED OUT TO BE THE VERSION HAMID HAD BEEN HOPING FOR — SERIOUS, BRILLIANT, EVENTUALLY A MARINE BIOLOGIST AT IIT MADRAS.

THE KIND OF SON YOU MENTION AT FAMILY GATHERINGS WITH A CAREFUL, CONTROLLED PRIDE.

ZARA TURNED OUT TO BE THE OTHER VERSION.

THE ONE WHO LISTENED WHEN HAMID TALKED ABOUT THE PORT'S SHADOW ECONOMY, UNDERSTOOD THE MECHANICS OF IT TOO WELL, AND DECIDED YOUNG THAT THE LEGAL ROUTE WAS SLOWER AND THE ILLEGAL ONE WAS FASTER AND SHE WAS NOT A PATIENT PERSON.

BY SEVENTEEN SHE WAS RUNNING MESSAGES FOR A MID-TIER IMPORT OPERATION.

BY NINETEEN SHE WAS RUNNING A CELL OF IT.

BY TWENTY-TWO SHE HAD CARVED OUT HER OWN TERRITORY ON THE SOUTHERN APPROACH LANES —

NOT NARCOTICS, WHICH SHE CONSIDERED LOW-MARGIN AND HIGH-HEAT, BUT EVERYTHING ELSE: ELECTRONICS, PHARMACEUTICALS, THE GREY-MARKET GOODS THAT MOVED THROUGH THE BAY OF BENGAL IN QUANTITIES THAT WOULD SURPRISE ANYONE WHO HAD NOT LOOKED CLOSELY AT THE NUMBERS.

SHE WAS GOOD AT THE SEA. SHE WAS BETTER AT IT THAN ANYONE SHE HAD EVER MET.

SHE DIVED FREE TO DEPTHS THAT MADE THE OTHER RUNNERS NERVOUS.

SHE READ CURRENTS THE WAY HER BROTHER READ RESEARCH PAPERS — FLUENTLY, AUTOMATICALLY, WITH THE SPECIFIC PLEASURE OF SOMEONE DOING THE THING THEY WERE BUILT FOR.

SHE HAD NO EXPLANATION FOR THIS. SHE DID NOT LOOK FOR ONE.

SOME PEOPLE ARE JUST BUILT FOR WATER. THE SEA DOES NOT OWE YOU A REASON

HER MOTHER HAD LEFT WHEN ZARA WAS SEVEN.

HER FATHER DIED OF A CARDIAC EVENT WHEN SHE WAS TWENTY-FOUR, TWO WEEKS AFTER SHE HAD FINALLY, FINALLY MANAGED TO PUT ENOUGH MONEY TOGETHER TO PAY OFF THE DEBT THAT HAD BEEN STRANGLING HIS RETIREMENT.

HE NEVER KNEW SHE HAD DONE IT.

SHE DID NOT ATTEND THE OFFICIAL FUNERAL — THERE WAS A COAST GUARD PROBLEM THAT WEEK —

BUT SHE WENT TO THE WATER AFTER, THE WAY HER FAMILY DID FOR ALL THE IMPORTANT THINGS.

AND SHE SAID WHAT SHE NEEDED TO SAY THERE.

SHE HAD IMRAN.
SHE HAD HER CREW.
SHE HAD THE SEA.
SHE CONSIDERED THIS SUFFICIENT.

SHE WAS WRONG.

BUT SHE WOULD NOT FIND THAT OUT FOR ANOTHER FIVE YEARS.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 2:
PRISON

PUZHAL CENTRAL PRISON
CHENNAI

THE NCB RAID ON HER OPERATION IN 2019 WAS NOT BAD LUCK.
IT WAS A BETRAYAL.

SHE HAD BEEN CAREFUL ENOUGH THAT BAD LUCK ALONE COULD NOT HAVE FOUND HER.

SOMEONE TALKED.
SHE KNEW WHO WITHIN SIX MONTHS OF BEING INSIDE.

WHICH WAS USEFUL INFORMATION TO FILE AWAY AND USELESS FOR ANYTHING IMMEDIATE.

PUZHAL CENTRAL PRISON, CHENNAI.
SHE SERVED TWENTY-SIX MONTHS OF A FOUR-YEAR SENTENCE BEFORE A PROCEDURAL ERROR IN THE PROSECUTION'S CHAIN-OF-CUSTODY DOCUMENTATION GAVE HER LAWYER SOMETHING TO WORK WITH.

SHE DOES NOT TALK ABOUT THE INSIDE.

THE CHARGES WERE REDUCED.
SHE WAS RELEASED ON A TUESDAY MORNING WITH A PLASTIC BAG CONTAINING HER PHONE, HER WATCH, AND TWO THOUSAND RUPEES.

WHAT SHE WILL SAY, IF PRESSED, IS THAT IT CLARIFIED THINGS — THE WAY COLD WATER CLARIFIES THINGS. YOU GO IN MURKY AND YOU COME OUT KNOWING EXACTLY WHAT YOU ARE AND WHAT YOU ARE NOT.

WHAT SHE LEARNED:
SHE WAS NOT SOMEONE WHO WOULD BE CONTAINED AGAIN. BY A CELL, BY A SYSTEM, BY A PERSON.

SHE WOULD DO WHATEVER WAS REQUIRED TO ENSURE THIS.

SHE WAS NOT SENTIMENTAL ABOUT WHAT "WHATEVER WAS REQUIRED" MIGHT INCLUDE.

HER CREW HAD HELD TOGETHER — RAJAN, HER LOGISTICS HEAD, HAD KEPT THINGS MOVING AT REDUCED CAPACITY, TAKING NO UNNECESARY RISKS.

THIS WAS THE CORRECT DECISION AMD SHE TOLD HIM SO. WHICH WAS HOW RAJAN KNEW SHE HAD GENUINNLY CHANGED: THE OLD ZARA WOULD HAVE BEEN FRUSTRATED THAT THINGS HAD SLOWED DOWN. THE NEW ZARA WAS GRATEFUL THE OPERATION STILL EXISTED TO SLOW DOWN.

SHE REBUILT CAREFULLY OVER EIGHTEEN MONTHS. SHE PERSONSALY HANDLED LESS, SUPERVISED MORE. SHE BROUGHT IN A FORMER COAST GUARD SIGNALS OFFICER WHO KNEW THE PATROL SCHEDULES BETTER THAN THE COAST GUARD ITSELF.

- NEW ROUTES.
- NEW CONTACTS.
- TIGHTER CELLS.
- LESS EXPOSURE BETWEEN THEM.
- FORMER COAST GUARD SIGNALS OFFICER.
- LEANER OPERATION.
- FASTER.
- HARDER TO TOUCH.

THE NARCOTICS CHARGE FROM 2019 STILL SAT ON THE BOOKS.

NARCOTICS CASE - 2019

ON RECORD

A SECOND CONVICTION WOULD BE A LONG SENTENCE WITH NO PROCEDURAL SALVATION. SHE KNEW THIS. SHE OPERATED ACCORDINGLY.

IN THE HOURS BEFORE DAWN WHEN THE PORT WAS QUIET AND THE BAY TURNED A PARTICULLAR SHADE OF DARK GREEN THAT SHE COULD NOT DESCRIBE TO ANYONE WHO HAD NOT SEEN IT, SHE WENT DIVING ALONE.

NOT FOR WORK. FOR HERSELF.

DEEPER EACH TIME THAN MADE SENSE FOR A PERSON WITHOUT EQUIPMENT.

SHE HAD ALWAYS BEEN ABLE TO GO DEEPER THAN SHE SHOULD.

SHE WAS NEVER EXAMINED WHY.

SHE WAS ABOUT TO FIND OUT.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 3: THE FORT

THE FORT HAD NO OFFICIAL NAME ON ANY CURRENT MARITIME CHART. IT APPEARED ON COLONIAL-ERA SURVEYS AS FORT ST. DOMINIC — A PORTUGUESE GUN PLATFORM BUILT IN THE 1640S, SUBSEQUENTLY EXPANDED BY THE DUTCH, SUBSEQUENTLY ABANDONED.

BY THE TIME ANYONE WITH A RESEARCH BUDGET MIGHT HAVE WANTED TO EXCAVATE IT, IT WAS THIRTY METRES BELOW THE SURFACE AND THE BAY OF BENGAL HAD COLONISED EVERY ROOM.

ZARA HAD FOUND IT ON HER FIFTH SOLO DIVE OF THAT SEASON, FOLLOWING A CURRENT ANOMALY THAT HER BODY HAD REGISTERED BEFORE HER MIND DID — A PULL, A WRONGNESS IN THE WATER'S DIRECTIONED BY THE TRACKED THE WAY YOU TRACK A SMELL.

SHE HAD GONE DOWN WITH A TORCH AND CAME UP TWO HOURS LATER HAVING FOUND THE FORT'S OUTER WALLS, A COLLAPSED GATEHOUSE, AND A COURTYARD COLONISED BY FEATHERSTAR CRINOIDS SO DENSE THEY LOOKED LIKE A FIELD OF MOVING RED FLOWERS.

SHE WENT BACK SIX MORE TIMES.
SHE MAPPED IT.
SHE CLAIMED IT — NOT LEGALLY, NOT FORMALLY, BUT IN THE WAY THAT PEOPLE WHO LIVE BY OLDER RULES THAN PROPERTY LAW CLAIM THINGS: BY KNOWING IT BETTER THAN ANYONE ELSE, BY RETURNING TO IT, BY MAKING IT HERS.

ON THE SEVENTH DIVE SHE WENT DEEPER THAN SHE HAD EVER GONE, FOLLOWING THE FORT'S INNER PASSAGE DOWN A SLOPE OF SETTLED RUBBLE INTO A LOWER CHAMBER THAT THE SEA HAD NOT ENTIRELY FILLED.

THERE WAS A POCKET OF PRESSURISED AIR AT THE TOP, OLD AND STALE AND STRANGE, THAT HAD SURVIVED IN THE SEALED VAULT FOR REASONS SHE COULD NOT IMMEDIATELY EXPLAIN.

SHE CAME UP INTO IT AND FLOATED ON HER BACK IN THE DARK WITH THE TORCH BALANCED ON A STONE LEDGE AND THOUGHT: THIS IS MINE. THIS SPECIFIC SILENCE, IN THIS SPECIFIC DARK, BELONGS TO ME.

THAT WAS WHEN THE FLOOR MOVED. NOT AN EARTHQUAKE. SHE HAD FELT EARTHQUAKES UNDERWATER — THEY WERE ALL DIRECTION, A SHUDDER THAT CAME FROM EVERYWHERE AT ONCE.

THIS WAS A SINGLE POINT SOURCE, DIRECTLY BENEATH HER, A VERTICAL FORCE PUSHING UPWARD THROUGH THE ROCK AND THROUGH THE WATER AND THROUGH THE SEALED AIR AND INTO HER WHERE SHE FLOATED.

IT WAS NOT VIOLENT. IT WAS ALMOST GENTLE, THE WAY A CURRENT IS GENTLE — INSISTENT, PATIENT, GOING ONLY IN ONE DIRECTION.

SOMETHING THAT HAD BEEN WAITING IN THE BEDROCK OF THE BAY OF BENGAL FOR GEOLOGICAL TIME, COILED IN THE DEEP-EARTH FLUID CHANNELS THAT RAN BENEATH THIS SPECIFIC LATITUDE, FOUND A SURFACE IN HER.

SHE WAS THE MOST WATER-CONGRUENT THING THAT HAD EVER ENTERED THE CONVERGENCE POINT'S RANGE. HER BODY, WHICH HAD ALWAYS RUN ON WATER'S LOGIC, WAS THE PATH OF LEAST RESISTANCE.

ZAL-SHAKTI MOVED INTO HER THE WAY WATER MOVES INTO A CRACK — INEVITABLY, COMPLETELY, FINDING EVERY SPACE.

SHE SANK.

THEN, BEFORE SHE COULD DROWN, SHE BREATHED WATER AND FOUND IT WAS FINE.

THEN SHE DISSOLVED, BRIEFLY, INTO THE BAY ITSELF — WHICH WAS THE MOST ALARMING THIRTY SECONDS OF HER LIFE —

AND THEN SHE RECONSTITUTED ON THE SURFACE, GASPING NOT FROM SUFFOCATION BUT FROM SHEER SHOCK, FLOATING ON HER BACK IN THE PRE-DAWN DARK THREE HUNDRED METRES FROM THE FORT WITH THE ENTIRE BAY PRESSING AGAINST HER SKIN LIKE A LIVING THING THAT KNEW HER NAME.

SHE FLOATED THERE FOR A LONG TIME, STARING AT THE STARS.

Alright. Fine. What do you want from me?

THE OCEAN, IN ITS WAY, ANSWERED. SHE WOULD SPEND THE NEXT SEVERAL MONTHS WORKING OUT WHAT IT HAD SAID.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 4:

THE POWER

ARJUN MEHTA, SIX HUNDRED KILOMETRES NORTH, HAD SPENT TWO MONTHS LEARNING HIS POWER LIKE AN ENGINEER — METHODICALLY, INCREMENTALLY, WITH RIGOROUS TESTING PROTOCOLS AND CAREFUL DOCUMENTATION OF RESULTS.

HE HAD KEPT A NOTEBOOK.

ZARA LEARNED HERS BY ACCIDENT, IN THE COURSE OF BUSINESS, OVER APPROXIMETLY THREE WEEKS OF OPERATIONAL CHAOS THAT SHE WILL EVENTRALLY DESC[illegible] IF SHE IS IN A GOOD MOOD, AS "DEEPLY INCONVENIENT."

DAY ONE.
SHE PULLED A SUBMERGED CRATE FROM TWENTY METRES WITHOUT DIVING FOR IT. SHE HAD REACHED TOWARD THE WATER AND THE CRATE HAD COME.

DAY ONE.

RAJAN, WHO WITNESSED THIS, SAID NOTHING FOR A FULL MINUTE AND THEN ASKED IF SHE WANTED TEA.

DAY THREE.
SHE WALKED INTO THE BAY FULLY CLOTHED DURING A COAST GUARD INTERCEPTION AND DID NOT SURFACE FOR ELEVEN MINUTES.

THE COAST GUARD CONCLUDED SHE HAD DROWNED. SHE WAS, IN FACT, SITTING ON THE BOTTOM WATCHING THEIR BOAT'S HULL FROM BELOW AND READING THE HULL NUMBER.

SHE MEMORISED IT. IT WAS USEFUL INFORMATION.

DAY SIX.
SHE LOST HER TEMPER AT A SUPPLIER WHO HAD SHORTED A SHIPMENT AND ACCIDENTALLY DRENCHED HIM WITH EVERY DROP OF WATER IN A TWENTY-METRE RADIUS.

INCLUDING THE CONTENTS OF THREE CHAI GLASSES, A FIRE BUCKET, AND A MUNICIPAL PIPE THAT HAD BEEN BEHAVING ITSELF UNTIL THAT MOMENT.

SHE PAID HIM DOUBLE FOR THE INSULT AND TOLD HIM TO FORGET IT. HE FORGOT IT. HE ALSO NEVER SHORTED A SHIPMENT AGAIN.

DAY ELEVEN.
SHE DISCOVERED SHE COULD FEEL THROUGH WATER. NOT METAPHORICALLY — LITERALLY, TACTICALLY, THE WAY YOU FEEL THROUGH YOUR OWN SKIN.

EVERY VESSEL IN THE HARBOUR REGISTERED TO HER AS A PRESENCE, A WEIGHT, A DIRECTION.

SHE SAT ON THE FORT WALL THAT MORNING AND MAPPED, WITHOUT LOOKING, THE POSITION OF EVERY SHIP, EVERY SWIMMER, EVERY LARGE FISH IN A TWO-KILOMETRE RADIUS.

IT WAS OVERWHELMING AND THEN, AS SHE LEARNED TO TUNE IT, USEFUL.

IT WAS THE BEST SURVEILLANCE SYSTEM SHE HAD EVER OPERATED AND IT COST NOTHING.

DAY EIGHTEEN. THE HYDRO-PHASE.

SHE HAD BEEN EXPERIMENTING WITH THE DISSOLUTION — THE THING SHE HAD DONE ACCIDENTALLY IN THE CONVERGENCE CHAMBER — AND SHE MANAGED TO DO IT DELIBERATELY IN SHALLOW WATER, MOVING TWENTY TH[illegible] REASSEMBLING STANDING ON A ROCK HER CREW HAD BEEN SITTING ON.

RAJAN FELL OFF THE ROCK.

SHE CAUGHT HIM BEFORE HE HIT THE WATER BECAUSE SHE HAD DONE THAT ON PURPOSE TOO.

HER CREW, TO THEIR CONSIDERABLE CREDIT, ADAPTED.

THEY HAD WORKED FOR A WOMAN WHO COULD NAVIGATE A STORM BY SMELL AND READ A COAST GUARD PATROL PATTERN FROM THREE MONTHS OF DATA ALONE.

A WOMAN WHO WAS NOW ALSO PARTLY MADE OF WATER WAS UNUSUAL BUT NOT, IN THEIR PROFESSIONAL ASSESSMENT, A DEAL-BREAKER.

SHE TOLD IMRAN NOTHING.

THIS WAS NOT A DIFFICULT DECISION.

WHAT WOULD SHE SAY? HER BROTHER WORKED IN MARINE BIOLOGY. HE BELIEVED IN SYSTEMS AND EVIDENCE AND PEER REVIEW.

SHE WAS NOT GOING TO CALL HIM AND SAY "THE SEA GAVE ME POWERS."

SHE WAS GOING TO USE THE POWERS, DO HER JOB, AND KEEP HER BROTHER IN THE CLEAN BRIGHT WORLD WHERE SHE HAD ALWAYS WANTED HIM TO BE.

THIS DECISION, LIKE MOST DECISIONS MADE OUT OF LOVE, WOULD EVENTUALLY COST HER.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 5:

FIRST TEAM

THEY CAME ON A THURSDAY. FOUR OF THEM, ARRIVING BY INFLATABLE AT 2 AM TO THE NORTH SIDE OF THE FORT — HER FORT, THE ONE SHE HAD NOT PUBLICISED, THE ONE THAT DID NOT APPEAR ON CURRENT CHARTS.

THE FACT THAT THEY FOUND IT TOLD HER IMMEDIATELY THAT THEY **HAD RESOURCES** BEYOND THE ORDINARY.

THE FACT THAT THEY CAME AT 2 AM IN BLACK WETSUITS TOLD HER THEY WERE NOT COAST GUARD. THESE WERE ACQUISITION PEOPLE.

SHE WAS IN THE WATER BEFORE THEY REACHED THE FORT. NOT HIDING — SHE HAD NO NEED TO HIDE. SHE WAS LISTENING.

SHE FOLLOWED BELOW THEM, WATCHING THEIR HULL FROM UNDERNEATH, UNTIL SHE UNDERSTOOD THEIR APPROACH VECTOR AND THEIR OBJECTIVE: THEY WERE GOING TO **THE CONVERGENCE CHAMBER.**

THEY KNEW IT WAS THERE. THEY HAD INSTRUMENTS — WATERTIGHT, EXPENSIVE.

SHE SURFACED BETWEEN THEM AND THE FORT ENTRANCE, RISING FROM NOTHING, SEA WATER SHEETING OFF HER IN THE DARK.

Private property.

ONE OF THEM HAD THE PRESENCE OF MIND TO SHINE A LIGHT.

THE TEAM LEADER SAID SOMETHING IN A LANGUAGE SHE DID NOT RECOGNISE. THEN, SWITCHING TO ACCENTED ENGLISH:

We have no quarrel with you. Stand aside.

You're in my bay. That's already a quarrel.

THEY WERE GOOD. PROFESSIONALLY TRAINED, EQUIPPED, OPERATING WITH THE COORDINATED EASE OF PEOPLE WHO HAD DONE EXTRACTION WORK BEFORE.

UNDER NORMAL CIRCUMSTANCES SHE WOULD HAVE BEEN OUTMATCHED BY FOUR TO ONE.

THESE WERE NOT NORMAL CIRCUMSTANCES.

SHE HAD THE BAY.

SHE DOES NOT DESCRIBE IN DETAIL WHAT HAPPENED IN THE NEXT FOUR MINUTES.

WHAT SHE WILL CONFIRM: ALL FOUR OF THEM WERE **ALIVE** WHEN IT WAS OVER.

THREE OF THEM WERE ON THE NEAREST PIECE OF SHORE, GASPING, HAVING BEEN DEPOSITED THERE BY A CURRENT SHE HAD GENERATED.

ONE — THE TEAM LEADER — SHE HELD IN A COLUMN OF WATER TWELVE FEET ABOVE THE BAY'S SURFACE FOR LONG ENOUGH TO MAKE HER POINT, THEN LOWERED GENTLY.

SHE TOOK THEIR EQUIPMENT. THEIR INSTRUMENTS, THEIR CASES, THEIR COMMUNICATIONS GEAR.

EVERYTHING WENT TO THE BOTTOM OF THE BAY IN A LOCATION SHE REMEMBERED AND NO ONE ELSE COULD REACH.

SHE DID NOT KNOW WHO HAD SENT THEM. SHE DID NOT KNOW ABOUT THE BHARATVERSE — THE ELEMENTAL FORCES, THE FIVE CONVERGENCE POINTS, THE ORGANISATION THAT HAD TAKEN A PHYSICIST'S SISTER FROM A FACILITY IN NAGPUR.

SHE KNEW ONLY THAT SOMEONE WITH SIGNIFICANT RESOURCES WANTED WHAT WAS UNDER HER FORT, AND THAT THIS WAS NOW A PROBLEM.

SHE WENT BACK TO HER CREW AND TOLD THEM TO DOUBLE THE PERIMETER WATCH.

TWO MONTHS LATER, A SECOND TEAM CAME. BETTER EQUIPPED. SIX PEOPLE THIS TIME.

THEY ALSO DID NOT SUCCEED.

ONE OF THEM, BEFORE SHE SENT HIM BACK TO SHORE, SAID:

You don't know what you're protecting.

SHE SAID: "I KNOW IT'S MINE."

They'll send more.

SHE SAID: **"SEND THEM."**

NONE OF THIS MADE HER A HERO.

SHE WAS PROTECTING HER TERRITORY.

THE FACT THAT HER TERRITORY HAPPENED TO CONTAIN SOMETHING OF ENORMOUS IMPORTANCE TO A CONFLICT SHE DID NOT YET UNDERSTAND WAS, AT THIS POINT, INCIDENTAL.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 6:
IMRAN

HER BROTHER HAD KNOWN SHE WAS A CRIMINAL SINCE SHE WAS NINETEEN. HE WAS NOT NAIVE. HE WAS PRECISE IN HIS **THINKING**. HE LOOKED AT THE EVIDENCE AND ARRIVED AT THE CORRECT CONCLUSION WITHOUT BEING TOLD.

HE HAD SAID, ONCE, WHEN THEY WERE SITTING ON THE MARINA BEACH AT SUNSET EATING CORN.

I'm not going to ask. You're not going to tell me. We're going to sit here and I'm going to pretend you work in import-export, which is technically true, and you're going to make sure I never have to know more than that. Yes?

Yes.

THEY HAD EATEN THEIR CORN. THIS **WAS THE AGREEMENT**.

IT HELD FOR TEN YEARS. THEN IMRAN STARTED PUBLISHING RESEARCH ON ANOMALOUS DEEP-EARTH FLUID CHANNELS IN THE BAY OF BENGAL.

Anomalous Subsurface Fluid Channels off the Tamil Nadu Coast: Preliminary Analysis

Imran Shaikh
Department of Marine Biology
IIT Madras

HIS PAPERS WERE CAREFUL, RIGOROUS, AND ATTRACTED THE ATTENTION OF A VISITING RESEARCH TEAM FROM AN INSTITUTE SHE COULD NOT FIND A PHYSICAL ADDRESS FOR.

HIS RESEARCH FOCUSED ON THE BEHAVIOUR OF CERTAIN GEOLOGICAL FORMATIONS OFF THE TAMIL NADU COAST THAT WERE PRODUCING PRESSURE READINGS INCONSISTENT WITH KNOWN TECTONIC PATTERNS.

THE VISITING TEAM'S INTEREST IN HIS RESEARCH MATCHED, TOO PRECISELY TO BE COINCIDENTAL, THE LOCATION OF THE CONVERGENCE POINT UNDER HER FORT.

SHE FOUND OUT ABOUT THIS BECAUSE SHE MONITORED HIS PROFESSIONAL CORRESPONDENCE. NOT AS A SISTER — AS SOMEONE WHOSE SECURITY PERIMETER INCLUDED HER BROTHER'S PROXIMITY TO ANYTHING DANGEROUS.

Inbox

- Research Collaboration — We are interested in your r...
- Visiting Research Team — Further discussion on subs...
- Data Request — Geological formation model...
- Re: Fluid Channel Analysis — Thank you for your response...

SHE HAD DONE THIS QUIETLY FOR YEARS. HE DID NOT KNOW. SHE WAS NOT PROUD OF IT. SHE WOULD NOT STOP.

SHE DROVE TO IIT MADRAS AND SAT IN THE CAR PARK FOR TWENTY MINUTES. THEN SHE WENT IN.

IIT MADRAS

SHE TOLD IMRAN SHE NEEDED HIM TO DELAY HIS NEXT PUBLICATION. NO EXPLANATION. JUST: WAIT, SIX MONTHS, TRUST ME.

I need you to delay your next publication. Six months. Trust me.

This is the import-export thing, isn't it?

Don't ask.

IMRAN LOOKED AT HER FOR A LONG TIME.

Are you safe?

SHE SAID:

Yes.

HE SAID:

Are you sure?

SHE SAID:

I'm always sure.

HE SAID:

That's not an answer, that's a habit.

SHE SAID:

Six months, Imran.

HE DELAYED THE PUBLICATION. HE ASKED FOR NOTHING IN RETURN.

Anomalous Subsurface Fluid Channels off the Tamil Nadu Coast: Preliminary Analysis

Imran Shaikh
Department of Marine Biology
IIT Madras

Submission Status
Delayed
Resubmission date: 6 months later

SHE DROVE BACK TO THE PORT AND SAT IN HER CAR FOR ANOTHER TWENTY MINUTES.

WHICH WAS THE CLOSEST SHE CAME, **THAT YEAR**, TO CRYING.

SHE COULD NOT KEEP HIM SAFE BY KEEPING HIM IGNORANT FOREVER.

SHE WAS BEGINNING TO UNDERSTAND THIS. SHE WAS NOT READY TO ACT ON IT YET.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 7:

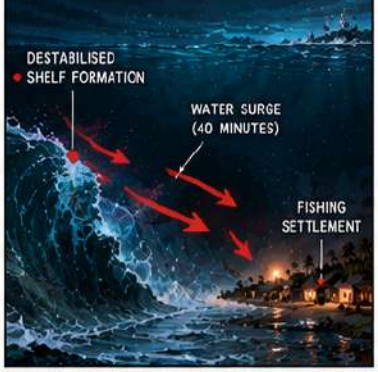
THE VILLAGE

SHE DID NOT CHOOSE TO SAVE THE VILLAGE. SHE CHOSE TO INVESTIGATE AN ANOMALOUS CURRENT THREE KILOMETRES OFF THE NAGAPATTINAM COAST.

SHE DETECTED A DEEP-WATER SURGE MOVING WRONG, FAST, TOWARD SHALLOW FISHING GROUNDS.

THE INVESTIGATION LED HER TO A TRAWLER OPERATING AN ILLEGAL SEAFLOOR DREDGE THAT WAS DESTABILISING A SHELF FORMATION.

THE SHELF, DESTABILISED, WAS GOING TO REDIRECT A SIGNIFICANT VOLUME OF WATER DIRECTLY INTO A SMALL FISHING SETTLEMENT IN APPROXIMATELY FORTY MINUTES.



SHE COULD HAVE NOTED THIS AND LEFT. SHE HAD NO OBLIGATION TO ANYONE IN THAT VILLAGE.

SHE STOPPED THE SURGE. SHE REROUTED IT — HELD THE WATER COLUMN IN A TEMPORARY CONFIGURATION LONG ENOUGH FOR THE SETTLEMENT TO GET THEIR BOATS IN AND MOVE THEIR CHILDREN TO HIGHER GROUND.

THE SURGE, WHEN IT CAME, ARRIVED DIMINISHED. DAMAGING BUT SURVIVABLE.

NOBODY DROWNED.

A FISHERMAN'S WIFE WHO HAD SEEN SOMETHING — A WOMAN-SHAPED DISPLACEMENT IN THE SURGE'S REDIRECTION — LEFT A MARIGOLD **GARLAND ON** THE BEACH THE NEXT MORNING.

ZARA SAW IT ON HER PRE-DAWN DIVE.

SHE FLOATED IN FRONT OF IT FOR A WHILE. THEN SHE WENT BACK TO WORK.

SHE WAS NOT TRANSFORMED BY THIS EXPERIENCE.

SHE FILED IT QUIETLY: SHE COULD DO THINGS THAT WERE USEFUL BEYOND HER OPERATION, AND THIS WAS OCCASIONALLY WORTH DOING, AND IT COST HER NOTHING BUT TIME.

HER CREW NOTICED THAT HER PRE-DAWN DIVES GOT LONGER. THAT SHE RANGEG FURTHER ALONG THE COAST. THAT SHE CAME BACK SOMETIMES WITH THE EXPRESSION OF SOMEONE WHO HAS DEALT WITH SOMETHING AND IS DECIDING WHETHER TO THINK ABOUT IT.

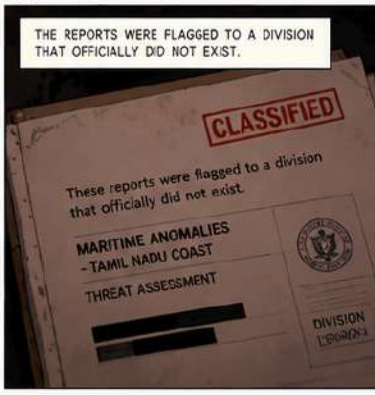
RAJAN NOTICED AND SAID NOTHING, BECAUSE SOME QUESTIONS WERE ABOVE HIS PAY GRADE.

HE JUST MADE SURE THERE WAS ALWAYS A FLASK OF FILTER COFFEE READY WHEN SHE GOT BACK.

THE COAST GUARD WAS STARTING TO FILE REPORTS ABOUT UNEXPLAINED CURRENT ANOMALIES AND APPARENT INTERVENTIONS IN NEAR-SHORE EVENTS ALONG THE TAMIL NADU COAST.



THE REPORTS WERE FLAGGED TO A DIVISION THAT OFFICIALLY DID NOT EXIST.



SHALINI BOSE, IN MUMBAI, READ THE FIRST ONE WITH SIGNIFICANT INTEREST.

SHE READ THE SECOND ONE WITH MORE.



SHE OPENED A NEW FILE.

SHE DID NOT YET KNOW THE NAME ZARA SHAIKH. SHE WOULD.

BHARATVERSE

JAL

THE OCEAN WITHIN

CHAPTER 8:
JAL BEGINS

SHE LEARNED THE NAME VAYU THE WAY EVERYONE ELSE DID — FROM THE NEWS, FROM THE TWELVE-SECOND CLIP OF A FIGURE MOVING THROUGH A MONSOON DISASTER ON THE BANDRA-WORLI WALKWAY.

SHE WATCHED IT THREE TIMES ON HER PHONE IN THE FORT'S SEALED CHAMBER, THE ONE THAT WAS HERS, THE ONE WITH THE CONVERGENCE POINT UNDER IT.

INDIA NEWS
BREAKING NEWS
0:12
MYSTERIOUS HERO "VAYU" SAVES HUNDREDS IN MUMBAI

SHE FELT IT WHEN SHE WATCHED IT. NOT RECOGNITION OF THE PERSON — SHE HAD NO IDEA WHO HE WAS. A RECOGNITION OF THE THING HE WAS CARRYING.

THE SAME FUNDAMENTAL QUALITY AS WHAT SHE CARRIED, EXPRESSED DIFFERENTLY — AIR INSTEAD OF WATER, STRUCTURE INSTEAD OF FLOW, BUT UNDERNEATH IT THE SAME ANCIENT WEIGHT, THE SAME GEOLOGICAL PATIENCE.

SHE UNDERSTOOD, WATCHING THE CLIP, THAT SHE WAS NOT ALONE IN THIS. SHE WAS NOT SURE HOW SHE FELT ABOUT THAT.

SHE DID NOT SEEK HIM OUT. SHE WOULD NOT SEEK HIM OUT. THE PART OF HER THAT HAD SURVIVED PRISON AND BETRAYAL WAS NOT GOING TO WALK TOWARD AN UNKNOWN WITH EXTRAORDINARY POWER BECAUSE THE POWER FELT FAMILIAR. THAT WAS NAIVE.

WHAT SHE DID INSTEAD WAS WHAT SHE ALWAYS DID: SHE EXTENDED HER RANGE, DEEPENED HER KNOWLEDGE, BUILT WHAT SHE HAD INTO SOMETHING MORE SOLID.

SHE MAPPED THE DEEP-FLUID CHANNELS BELOW THE COAST.

SHE PRACTICED THE PHASE-DISSOLUTION IN PROGRESSIVELY MORE COMPLEX CONDITIONS.

SHE LEARNED TO HOLD THE HYDRO-SENSE OPEN ACROSS LONGER DISTANCES UNTIL SHE COULD FEEL THE GEOMETRY OF THE BAY FLOOR AS CLEARLY AS SHE COULD FEEL THE ROOM SHE STOOD IN.

AND SHE WAITED, WITH THE PATIENT INTELLIGENCE OF WATER, FOR THE SHAPE OF THE THING TO BECOME CLEAR.

CONVERGENCE POINT

ALL FIVE POINTS BECOMING MORE ACTIVE.

SOMETHING WAS COMING.

THE WAY THE CONVERGENCE POINT PULSED BENEATH THE FORT TOLD HER — SHE COULD FEEL IT RESPONDING TO THE WORLD ABOVE, AS IF IT WAS AWARE OF THE OTHER POINTS, AS IF ALL FIVE OF THEM WERE BECOMING MORE ACTIVE.

A STORM BUILDING BELOW THE SURFACE OF EVERYTHING, SLOW AND ENORMOUS.

SHE HAD SURVIVED STORMS BEFORE. SHE KNEW HOW TO POSITION YOURSELF WHEN THE WATER MOVED WRONG: NOT AGAINST IT, NOT RUNNING FROM IT. YOU FOUND THE STILL POINT INSIDE IT AND YOU HELD.

ONE EVENING, SITTING ON THE FORT WALL WITH HER FEET IN THE WATER AND RAJAN'S FLASK OF COFFEE GOING COLD BESIDE HER, SHE THOUGHT ABOUT THE FISHERMAN'S WIFE'S MARIGOLD GARLAND.

ABOUT WHY IT HAD BOTHERED HER.

SHE THOUGHT:

I AM NOT A GUARDIAN. I AM NOT A PROTECTOR. I AM A LOGISTICS OPERATOR WHO CAN MAKE THE OCEAN DO WHAT I WANT.

SHE THOUGHT:

THE OCEAN DOES NOT CARE WHAT I CALL MYSELF.

SHE THOUGHT:

WATER FINDS THE LOWEST POINT AND FILLS IT.

FAR TO THE NORTH, ARJUN MEHTA WAS STANDING IN THE RAIN OUTSIDE A LAB IN PUNE.

RESEARCH LABORATORIES

FAR ABOVE THEM BOTH, IN THE HIMALAYAS, PRIYA WAS LEARNING WHAT SHE HAD BECOME.

AND BENEATH THE BAY OF BENGAL, THE JAL-SHAKTI CONVERGENCE POINT TURNED IN ITS ANCIENT BED LIKE A CREATURE THAT HAD BEEN SLEEPING FOR TEN THOUSAND YEARS AND WAS, AT LAST, WAKING UP.

ZARA DRANK THE COLD COFFEE. SHE WENT BACK TO WORK.

THE SEA WENT WITH HER.